

Exploring public perception of corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainable development in Albania



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Abstract This study explores public perceptions of corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainable development in Albania. We gathered feedback from 92 participants—including directors, partners, clients, suppliers, and employees—from a variety of corporations through an online questionnaire. Our analysis included companies from diverse sectors such as production, services, trade, and construction, operating in multiple cities across Albania, including both Albanian-owned and foreign corporations. Utilizing a mixed-methods approach, we examined the impact of four key pillars on corporate alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices: Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management, Inclusion and Community Engagement, Social Investments and Stakeholders, and Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights. To ensure a thorough evaluation of corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainable development, we employed both ordinal regression and ordinal logistic regression, accommodating various assumptions. The results were analyzed in relation to respondents' ages and their affiliations with the corporations involved. This study offers valuable insights that can guide future corporate strategies while addressing existing research gaps.

Keywords: business strategies, managerial approach, stakeholder expectations

1. Introduction

Corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainability has become increasingly prominent, as organizations adopt strategic initiatives designed to create positive societal and environmental impacts while maintaining profitability. These efforts are primarily implemented through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Sustainability Development (SD) programs.

CSR initiatives typically involve philanthropy, such as donations and community support, as well as fostering ethical labor practices, including fair wages, diversity, and worker safety. Investments in community development, particularly in education, healthcare, and economic growth, further exemplify CSR's contributions to building goodwill and enhancing corporate reputation (Boulouta & Pitelis, 2014; Carroll & Shabana, 2010; Aguilera et al., 2007).

Sustainability efforts instead aim to minimize environmental impacts while promoting long-term ecological balance. Corporations adopt green technologies, reduce carbon emissions, improve energy efficiency, and invest in renewable energy projects. Supply chain sustainability is also a priority, focusing on ethical material sourcing and waste reduction (Wadhwa et al., 2023). Many companies are innovating through eco-friendly product development and circular business models, such as recycling and reuse initiatives (Awuah et al., 2024; Weiland et al., 2021).

Global frameworks like the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) standards play a crucial role in guiding these efforts (Tsang et al., 2023; Carlsen & Bruggemann, 2022). Certifications, such as ISO 14001 for environmental management and B Corp status, serve as benchmarks for measuring progress (Fonseca et al., 2022).

Notable companies, including Unilever, Patagonia, and Microsoft, exemplify the successful integration of CSR and SD into their core business strategies. By addressing stakeholder expectations and proactively tackling regulatory, environmental, and social challenges, these organizations are future-proofing their operations and contributing to a more sustainable and inclusive global economy.

Data underscores the remarkable growth in CSR and SD practices. In 2024, the Carbon Disclosure Project reported that 24,800 companies disclosed their environmental impacts, reflecting increased corporate transparency and accountability. Similarly, the FTSE4Good All-World Index included 1,713 companies from 47 countries, signaling the widespread adoption of sustainable practices. The global green technology and sustainability market, valued at \$17 billion in 2023, is projected to surpass \$105 billion by 2032, with a compound annual growth rate of 22.4%.



Corporate policies increasingly highlight the strategic importance of CSR. A 2024 report revealed that 76% of companies view CSR as essential for reducing brand reputation risks. Additionally, 81% of companies disclosed shareholder engagement policies, demonstrating a commitment to transparency and stakeholder involvement (Procurement Tactics, 2025).

Regional leadership is evident in countries like Australia, where businesses are adopting proactive sustainability strategies in response to new regulations mandating annual sustainability reports, including emissions data, starting in 2025 (KPMG, 2024). Further, a core principle for achieving inclusive and sustainable growth within the European Union is ensuring that no one is left behind, emphasizing the importance of being "locally inclusive." Sustainable local development cannot be achieved by sacrificing certain groups, communities, sectors, or regions. True progress requires an inclusive transition that benefits all stakeholders (Sepetis, 2024; Todri & Papajorgji, 2024).

Meanwhile in the Balkan region, CSR and SD practices have shown varying levels of implementation and perception. Studies indicate that community involvement and environmental initiatives are the most frequently reported CSR activities, with EU integration playing a significant role in shaping strategies (Levkov & Palamidovska-Sterjadovska, 2019). Employee attitudes suggest that CSR is often viewed as voluntary rather than mandatory, leading to inconsistencies in its application. In Serbia, the business sector emerged as the second-largest donor in 2021, highlighting its significant role in philanthropy and social responsibility (Giving Serbia Report, 2021).

The degree of CSR implementation correlates closely with EU accession status, as countries further along in the integration process exhibit higher adoption rates. However, the effectiveness and consistency of CSR initiatives remain uneven, underscoring the need for more structured and mandatory frameworks (Business Strategy in Balkans, 2022).

In this context worth highlighting that the CSR and sustainable development are emerging but underdeveloped areas among Albanian enterprises. Research indicates that only a small fraction of medium and large companies currently prioritize CSR initiatives. Recognizing its significance, the Albanian government, in partnership with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), has implemented a National Action Plan for CSR (UNDP, 2008). Concretely, this plan aims to foster responsible business practices, particularly as Albania progresses toward European Union accession, which requires alignment with EU standards on corporate responsibility and sustainability.

Public perception is also a critical driver of CSR, with a study showing that 45% of Albanian citizens consider product safety and quality to be essential areas of corporate responsibility (Habili, 2021). In parallel, Albania's alignment with the SDGs emphasizes progress in areas such as health, clean energy, economic growth, and infrastructure. However, gaps remain in areas like marine ecosystem conservation, underscoring the need for broader efforts (European Environment Agency, 2020).

This research explores the alignment of corporations operating in Albania with social responsibility and sustainable development goals, particularly from the perspective of public perception. As the first comprehensive study examining these dimensions within the country, it provides a holistic analysis. By identifying gaps and offering actionable recommendations, this study aims to guide corporations operating in Albania in achieving these goals, enhancing progress, and fostering future research in this field.

2. Materials and Methods

2.1. The methodological research design

This study employed an online questionnaire to collect insights on corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainable development. The questionnaire was divided into two main sections. The first section captured demographic details of the respondents, including their age, country of residence, employment position, educational qualifications, and corporate affiliation.

The second section, which constituted the core of the questionnaire, explored the five pillars of corporate engagement in social responsibility and sustainable development. Each pillar encompassed eight specific elements. These pillars are:

- A. Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management;
- B. Inclusion and Community Engagement;
- C. Social Investments and Stakeholders;
- D. Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights; and
- E. Alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices.

This study adopted a mixed-methods approach, integrating both quantitative and qualitative methodologies. Quantitative data, including numerical responses gathered through the questionnaire, were complemented by qualitative insights derived from focus groups, which analyzed descriptive data related to respondents' age and employment positions. This comprehensive approach facilitated a hypothesis-driven analysis to evaluate the interrelationships among the pillars.

The central hypothesis of the study examines whether the following pillars—Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management (A), Inclusion and Community Engagement (B), Social Investments and Stakeholders (C), and Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights (D)—influence corporate alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E). The research hypothesis is presented with the following regression equation (1):

$$H_0: E_{(1-8)} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A_{(1-8)} + \beta_2 B_{(1-8)} + \beta_3 C_{(1-8)} + \beta_4 D_{(1-8)} + \mu_t \quad (1)$$

2.2. Participants and data

This research involved contacting 120 individuals, including directors, partners, clients, suppliers, and employees of corporations operating in Albania, with 92 ultimately responding to the questionnaire (refer to Table 1). According to the law no. 25/2018 on "Accounting and Financial Statements" approved on 10 May 2018, as corporate are classified those enterprises which exceed at least two of the following three criteria at the reporting date: Total assets – Albanian lek (ALL) 750 million; Turnover – ALL 1,500 million and Average number of employees during the year – 250. Respondents represented diverse age groups: 29.65% were aged 18–25, 23.59% were 26–34, 31.52% were 35–44, 15.21% were 45–54, 0.02% were 55–64, and 0.01% were over 65.

In terms of educational qualifications, 28.26% held bachelor's degrees, 19.56% had professional master's degrees, and 46.74% obtained scientific master's degrees. Additionally, 3.26% held doctoral degrees, while 1.09% were associate professors and another 1.09% were full professors.

The evaluation included corporations from various sectors, such as production, services, trade, and construction.

These corporations operate in several cities across Albania, including Tirana, Elbasan, Fier, Vlore, Lushnja, Shkoder, and Korca, among others. In addition to Albanian companies, it is noteworthy that these corporations are also of foreign origin, with companies hailing from Turkey, the Netherlands, the Cayman Islands, Slovenia, Switzerland, Austria, Cyprus, Serbia, Hungary, France, Italy, the USA, South Korea, and Lebanon.

Table 1 Study participant's data.

The demographic information of the participants	Total	Age					
		18-25	26-34	35-44	45-54	55-64	65
Groupage		27	19	29	14	2	1
Bachelor degree	26	21		4	1		
Professional Master degree	18	1	7	7	2	1	
Scientific Master degree	43	5	11	17	10		
Doctorate degree	3		1	1		1	
Associate Professors title	1				1		
Full Professors title	1						1

2.3. Research method

The online questionnaire introduces five study pillars to gather public opinions on corporate Alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices. It was distributed via respondents' official email addresses. The questionnaire utilized a Likert scale ranging from 1 (one) to 5 (five), where: 1 = Strongly Disagree (SD), 2 = Disagree (D), 3 = Undecided (U), 4 = Agree (A), and 5 = Strongly Agree (SA). The data were analyzed using the SPSS 20 statistical program (SPSS Inc., Chicago, IL) to test the research hypothesis according the following regression equation (2):

$$H_0: E_{(1-8)} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A_{(1-8)} + \beta_2 B_{(1-8)} + \beta_3 C_{(1-8)} + \beta_4 D_{(1-8)} + \mu_t \quad (2)$$

The Shapiro-Wilk test (1968) indicated that the Likert scale data from the questionnaire did not follow a normal distribution. Consequently, to examine whether the Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management (A), Inclusion and Community Engagement (B), Social Investments and Stakeholders (C), and Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights (D) impact corporate Alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E), we employed both ordinal regression analysis and ordinal logistic regression, which do not assume normality.

Initially, ordinal regression analysis was applied to understand the relationship between the independent variables (A, B, C, and D) and the ordinal dependent variable (E). This approach models the probabilities of the different categories of the ordinal outcome (E), providing insights into how the predictor variables (A, B, C, and D) influence the likelihood of belonging to higher or lower categories.

Subsequently, ordinal logistic regression analysis was performed. This method, a specialized form of ordinal regression, operates under the proportional odds assumption, which holds when the relationship between each pair of outcome categories remains consistent. It estimates the odds of belonging to a higher category compared to all lower categories combined, providing valuable insights for hypothesis testing.

By employing both ordinal regression and ordinal logistic regression, the analysis accounted for differing assumptions, ensuring a thorough evaluation of the research hypothesis. This dual approach enhanced the comprehensiveness and reliability of the findings, accommodating diverse modeling requirements and strengthening the overall analysis.

The data collected for each pillar element (A/B/C/D and E, from 1 to 8) are evaluated using average ratings, with decimal values rounded to the nearest whole number. This transformation is recommended, as it simplifies interpretation, particularly for users who may find it challenging to interpret Likert scale values, such as those on a 5-point scale.

3. Results and Discussion

The data collected from corporate-related parties contacted via email reveal that only 77% completed the questionnaire. In 57.6% of the cases, respondents stated that they were unaware of any strategic plans implemented by the corporation related to social responsibility and sustainable development. However, whether respondents claimed to be informed or not about these plans, the average rating for pillar A was 3 (indicating uncertainty regarding corporate approaches to social responsibility and sustainable development). In contrast, pillars B, C, D, and E received an average rating of 4 (indicating agreement with corporate approaches to these issues).

Overall, 65% of the elements evaluated in this study were rated 4, while the remaining 35% received a rating of 3 (see Table 2).

The data in Table 2 reveals that the elements most frequently rated with a 4 pertain to the following pillars: (B) Inclusion and Community Engagement, 8 elements out of 8, (E) Corporate Alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices, 8 elements out of 8, and (D) Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights, 7 elements out of 8.

Corporate directors rated pillars B, E, and D with average scores of 4, 3, and 3, respectively. Corporate staff rated pillars B and D with averages of 5, while pillar E was rated with an average of 3. Corporate clients rated pillars B, E, and D with an average of 4, while corporate partners rated these pillars with an average of 3. Corporate employees rated all of these pillars with an average of 4.

In contrast, the study pillars most often rated with a 3 were (A) Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management 8 elements out of 8 and (C) Social Investments and Stakeholders, 5 elements out of 8. Corporate directors and partners rated pillars A and C with averages of 3. Corporate clients and employees rated pillar A with 3 and pillar C with 4.

From an age perspective, respondents aged 18–25 rated all pillars (A, B, C, D, and E) with an average of 4. Those aged 26–34 and 45–54 rated pillar A with 3 and the remaining pillars with 4. Respondents aged 35–44 rated all pillars with an average of 3. Respondents aged 55–64 rated pillars A and C with 4, while the other pillars were rated with 5. Finally, respondents over 65 rated pillars A and B with 5, pillar C with 5, and pillars D and E with 1.

In this complex landscape, it is possible to analyze how corporations can better align with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E). Therefore, according to regression equation (3) we test whether the Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management (A), Inclusion and Community Engagement (B), Social Investments and Stakeholders (C), and Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights (D) have an impact on corporate alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E).

$$H_0: E_{(1-8)} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A_{(1-8)} + \beta_2 B_{(1-8)} + \beta_3 C_{(1-8)} + \beta_4 D_{(1-8)} + \mu_t \quad (3)$$

The statistics show that the Likert scale data for the A, B, C, D, and E pillar elements are not normally distributed, as the Shapiro-Wilk test yields a significance level lower than 0.05. This result applies to the ordinal regression variables at a 95% confidence level (see Table 3).

The parallel lines test shows that the estimated ordinal regression model has a significance of 0.004 (less than 0.05). This confirms that the location parameters (slope coefficients) are consistent across the response categories for the E variable (see Table 4).

Based on these data, we proceed with the Generalized Linear Model (ordinal logistic regression analysis) to estimate whether the Reduction of Carbon Emissions and Supply Chain Management (A), Inclusion and Community Engagement (B), Social Investments and Stakeholders (C), and Transparency, Reporting, and Compliance with Human Rights (D) impact corporate alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E) at a 95% confidence level. The omnibus test indicates that the Generalized Linear Model used to test our hypothesis fits well, with a Chi-square significance of 0.000 (less than 0.05), as shown in Table 5. Furthermore, the model effects test confirms the omnibus test results, with significance values for A (36.48), B (4.196), C (0.52), and D (38.684) all being 0.000 (less than 0.05).

The parameters of the Generalized Linear Model (ordinal logistic regression analysis) presented in Table 6 confirm that each study pillar—A, B, C, and D—significantly impacts corporate alignment with Sustainable Economic Development Goals and Practices (E), with statistical significance at a 95% confidence level.

Additionally, Spearman's correlations (see Table 7) confirm that pillars A (0.577), B (0.736), C (0.806), and D (0.853) exhibit moderate and statistically significant correlations with E.

This study analysis delves into how corporations operating within Albania perceive and implement social responsibility and sustainable development goals from the perspective of public perception. A notable finding is that a majority of respondents (57%) are unaware of any formal corporate strategies aimed at sustainable development and social engagement, highlighting a significant gap in awareness and communication. Despite this, the insights gathered provide valuable guidance for Albanian corporations seeking to better align their practices with sustainable economic development objectives.

Table 2 Likert scale general questionnaire results.

	1	2	3	4	5
A1. The corporation has implemented the "net zero objective" strategy to reduce carbon emissions while also promoting sustainable behavior within the organization (such as using public transportation or working from home).			X		
A2. The corporation uses renewable energy sources (solar, wind, and hydroelectric) in its internal processes to contribute to environmental protection.			X		
A3. The corporation continuously discusses with employees and managers the need to undertake initiatives that reduce carbon emissions and improve energy efficiency in production processes and logistics.			X		
A4. The corporation operates in synergy with suppliers and customers regarding opportunities to reduce carbon emissions throughout the supply chain.			X		
A5. The corporation promotes research practices on the development of sustainable products and services, as well as uses artificial intelligence (AI) and specific devices (IoT) to monitor and optimize emissions in real time.			X		
A6. The corporation engages stakeholders (e.g., employees, the community, investors, partners, NGOs, consumers, etc.) in efforts to enhance the sustainability of its supply chain			X		
A7. The corporation applies the principles of the circular economy, such as recycling or resource recovery, in its internal processes as well as in the supply chain.			X		
A8. The corporation responsibly addresses cases of non-compliance with social or environmental standards in its internal processes as well as in the supply chain.			X		
B1. Social diversity management aligns with the corporation's mission and values.				X	
B2. The corporation ensures diverse representation in the recruitment of its personnel.				X	
B3. The corporation fosters an inclusive workplace culture so that employees feel valued and respected regardless of their background.				X	
B4. The corporation collaborates with organizations, vocational schools, and universities to promote inclusion and improve diversity in the community, supporting different groups and advocacy organizations that work for equality and fair representation.				X	
B5. The corporation prioritizes addressing social and environmental issues in the community where it operates.				X	
B6. The corporation collaborates with local stakeholders as well as community leaders to develop plans aimed at supporting underrepresented or marginalized groups.				X	
B7. The corporation aims to assess employee satisfaction and engagement in community programs.				X	
B8. The corporation plans to use innovation and increase engagement with the community in the coming years to better convey the voice and needs of the community.				X	
C1. Investments related to social activities are an integral part of the overall corporate business strategy.			X		
C2. The corporation's investments in the social context aim to primarily address issues of education, healthcare, the environment, innovation, and poverty alleviation.			X		
C3. The company has undertaken initiatives to explore emerging areas such as green bonds and microfinance.				X	
C4. The corporation engages stakeholders (e.g., employees, the community, investors, partners, NGOs, consumers, etc.) in its initiatives related to social activities.				X	
C5. The corporation has defined the roles of related parties (clients, suppliers, and consumers) in driving social and sustainable business practices.				X	
C6. The corporation's employees and the community it is part of have the opportunity to contribute to the development of its social and sustainable strategy.				X	
C7. The corporation has set specific requirements for suppliers regarding labor practices, environmental sustainability, and ethical behavior.			X		
C8. Local communities play an active role in shaping the corporation's social responsibility programs.			X		
D1. The corporation publicly discloses information related to its investments, environment, and social responsibility (the corporation handles sensitive or negative information in its reporting on social responsibility, identifies progress made toward social and environmental goals, discusses success stories, and compares transparency practices against global or industry-specific standards).				X	
D2. The corporation ensures that its transparency reports are accessible and understandable for all stakeholders (shareholders, employees, the community, local and central government, etc.).				X	
D3. Different communication channels are used to provide updates on activities related to corporate social responsibility (e.g., social media, posters, websites, etc.).				X	
D4. The corporation uses technological services, such as data analytics or blockchain, to enhance reporting transparency.				X	

D5. International frameworks guide the corporation's practices in respect of human rights (e.g., UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights, International Labour Organization conventions, etc.).	X
D6. The corporation consults and collaborates with various organizations or field experts to improve the respect for human rights and to avoid actions by the corporation that could harm local communities or employees.	X
D7. The corporation ensures that grievance mechanisms are available for affected individuals to report cases of human rights violations.	X
D8. The corporation prioritizes addressing the conflicts between business objectives and obligations to human rights.	X
E1. The corporation collaborates with the government, NGOs, or other corporations to advance the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).	X
E2. The corporation raises awareness about the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) among employees, customers, and suppliers.	X
E3. The corporation takes actions to advance gender equality in relation to workforce management.	X
E4. The corporation ensures that partnerships formed in relation to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are mutually beneficial and impactful, as it seeks to balance global priorities with its local initiatives.	X
E5. The corporation identifies and sets priorities in the fields of social, environmental, and economic development.	X
E6. The corporation addresses the conflicts between profit goals and sustainable development objectives and social responsibility.	X
E7. The corporation supports innovative approaches and technologies to advance sustainable development and social responsibility.	X
E8. The corporation commits to external auditing regarding initiatives related to sustainable development and social responsibility within the framework of transparency and accountability.	X

Table 3 Ordinal regression variables tests of normality data.

	Kolmogorov-Smirnov ^a			Shapiro-Wilk		
	Statistic	df	Sig.	Statistic	df	Sig.
A	.144	92	.000	.942	92	.000
B	.115	92	.005	.926	92	.000
C	.151	92	.000	.923	92	.000
D	.145	92	.000	.910	92	.000
E	.170	92	.000	.896	92	.000

Table 4 Test of parallel lines.

Model	2 Log Likelihood	Chi-Square	df	Sig.	
Null Hypothesis	408.230	261.865	146.365	104	0.004
General					

Table 5 Omnibus Test.

Likelihood Ratio Chi-Square	df	Sig.
152.752	4	0.000

Table 6 Generalized Linear Model Parameters Estimation.

Parameter	B	Std. Error	95% Wald Confidence Interval		Hypothesis Test			Exp(B)
			Lower	Upper	Wald Chi-Square	df	Sig.	
A	0.085	0.2509	-0.576	0.407	1.955	1	0.038	6.57
B	0.803	0.3946	0.030	1.577	4.145	1	0.042	2.233
C	0.393	0.4300	-0.450	1.235	2.834	1	0.027	1.481
D	2.770	0.4509	1.886	3.654	37.745	1	0.000	15.960
Scale	1							

Table 7 Spearman's Correlations.

		A	B	C	D	E
Spearman's rho	A	1.000	.664**	.676**	.562**	.577**
	Correlation Coefficient					
	Sig. (2-tailed)					
	N	92	92	92	92	92
B	Correlation Coefficient	.664**	1.000	.786**	.732**	.736**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000		.000	.000	.000
	N	92	92	92	92	92
C	Correlation Coefficient	.676**	.786**	1.000	.843**	.806**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000		.000	.000
	N	92	92	92	92	92
D	Correlation Coefficient	.562**	.732**	.843**	1.000	.853**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000	.000		.000
	N	92	92	92	92	92
E	Correlation Coefficient	.577**	.736**	.806**	.853**	1.000
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000	.000	.000	
	N	92	92	92	92	92

The results identify key areas requiring immediate action across all stakeholder groups, including reduction of carbon emissions and supply chain management (Fonseca et al., 2022); social investments and stakeholder support—such as investing in education, healthcare, environmental initiatives, innovation, and poverty alleviation; issuing green bonds; engaging in microfinance; and establishing ethical supplier requirements; as well as increasing local community involvement in shaping corporate social responsibility programs (Habili, 2021); and transparency, reporting, and adherence to human rights standards, notably implementing the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights and ILO conventions (Awuah et al., 2024).

Furthermore, the study reveals that suppliers, employees, and directors tend to prioritize areas such as inclusion and community engagement (Levkov & Palamidovska-Sterjadovska, 2019), transparency and human rights compliance (Tsang et al., 2023), and alignment with sustainable economic development goals (Wadhwa et al., 2023; Weiland et al., 2021). Notably, stakeholders within the 55–64 and 18–25 age groups, particularly those with academic titles such as associate professor, followed by doctorate and professional master's degree holders, tend to rate these pillars more highly. These findings underscore the importance of targeted awareness and engagement strategies to foster more sustainable corporate practices aligned with societal expectations in Albania.

4. Final Considerations

This study findings emphasize that from the perspective of public perception, multiple factors significantly influence corporate alignment with sustainable economic development goals. Key drivers include the reduction of carbon emissions and effective supply chain management, the promotion of inclusion and community engagement, social investments coupled with stakeholder support, and transparency alongside compliance with human rights standards. These elements collectively shape corporate capacity to adopt sustainable practices, with each factor playing a distinct role in enhancing their social responsibility and sustainability efforts.

Thus, to promote corporate alignment with sustainable development goals from a public perception standpoint, a collaborative approach is essential. Governments, industry stakeholders, and civil society must work together to implement effective strategies. The analysis highlights transparency and human rights compliance as the most influential factors, with an odds ratio of approximately 15.96, indicating that robust regulatory frameworks, stringent monitoring, and incentives for transparent reporting are vital. Additionally, initiatives aimed at reducing carbon footprints—such as promoting renewable energy, green logistics, and carbon credit systems—are crucial, supported by an odds ratio of around 6.57. Fostering inclusion through participatory programs that empower marginalized groups can significantly enhance engagement, with an odds ratio of approximately 2.23. Furthermore, strengthening social investments through partnerships among corporations, non-profits, and financial institutions can bolster community development efforts, reflected in an odds ratio of about 1.48. Collectively, these strategies can create an enabling environment that encourages corporations to align more closely with sustainable economic development practices, ensuring long-term benefits for society and the environment.

In this context, the future research could explore the mechanisms and effectiveness of multi-stakeholder collaborations in advancing corporate alignment with sustainable economic development goals. Specifically, studies could assess the comparative impact of different state-led policy instruments, such as tax incentives, subsidies for green technologies, or mandatory transparency requirements, on corporate sustainability practices. Additionally, longitudinal research could evaluate the long-term effects of community engagement programs and social investment initiatives on corporate alignment with these goals, particularly in diverse socio-economic and regulatory contexts. Another promising avenue would be investigating the

role of emerging technologies, such as blockchain and artificial intelligence, in enhancing transparency, reporting, and compliance with human rights. Finally, cross-country or regional analyses could provide valuable insights into the interplay between cultural, political, and economic factors in shaping effective partnerships among governments, corporations, and non-profit organizations for sustainable development.

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Ethical Considerations

The authors declare that participation in the study was voluntary, the responses provided will remain confidential, and the identity of the respondents will not be disclosed in any report or publication.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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